

A second read

Saturday, September 12, 2026 · 10:45 PM

1 What You Received

I just saw that my son received a 68 on his project. He told me the directions and grading rubric were never clearly explained. He normally earns high grades, so this does not seem fair. I have also heard from other parents who are unhappy with this assignment. I expect the grade to be reconsidered by tomorrow; otherwise, I will contact the principal.

2 What You Planned to Say

The rubric was explained several times, and most students completed the project without difficulty. Your son spent part of the assigned work time talking instead of asking for help. I cannot change grades simply because a parent is unhappy with the result. If he had paid closer attention and followed the directions, his grade would have been higher. I teach more than 100 students and cannot individually repeat every direction. The grade will remain as entered.

Overall: The planned response contains understandable frustration, but as written it's likely to escalate the conflict rather than resolve it — it reads as defensive and places blame on the student rather than addressing the parent's concerns.

What works well:

You're clear that the rubric was communicated and that most students managed the assignment, which is useful factual context. You're also right to hold a boundary around not changing grades solely due to parent pressure — that instinct to protect grading integrity is reasonable.

What may create a problem:

Several parts of this message could backfire:

- Telling a parent their child "talked instead of asking for help" or "if he had paid closer attention" reads as blaming the student and could come across as scolding rather than informative. Even if true, it's likely to put the parent on the defensive rather than open a conversation.
- "I cannot change grades simply because a parent is unhappy" and "I teach more than 100 students and cannot individually repeat every direction" sound defensive and dismissive. They may be factually fine points, but the tone will likely overshadow the content.
- The message doesn't address the fact that other parents have also raised concerns — ignoring that entirely may look evasive, especially if this becomes a pattern worth mentioning to an administrator.
- There's no offer of a concrete next step (reviewing the specific project, explaining the rubric again, inviting a meeting), which leaves the parent's request for reconsideration unanswered except with a flat refusal.
- The final line, "The grade will remain as entered," delivered with no other supportive framing, will likely read as a door slamming shut, which may accelerate the parent's threat to contact the principal rather than de-escalate it.

Recommended changes:

- Remove language that blames the student for talking or not paying attention. Stick to neutral, observable facts about how the rubric was communicated and shared.
- Cut the line about not being able to repeat directions for 100 students — even though it's true, it minimizes the parent's concern instead of addressing it.
- Acknowledge the parent's frustration and the fact that other families raised concerns, without agreeing

the grade was unfair. You can validate the emotion without conceding the point.

- Offer a concrete next step: for example, reviewing the rubric together, explaining how the grade was calculated, or scheduling a brief call. This shows good faith even while holding your position on the grade itself.

- Since multiple parents are apparently unhappy with the same assignment, it may be worth mentioning this to an administrator or department colleague proactively, so you're not the only one addressing a pattern of concern — not because anything went wrong, but so leadership isn't blindsided if the principal is contacted.

Consider administrator involvement:

Since multiple parents have reportedly raised concerns about the same assignment, it may be worth briefly informing an administrator now, before any single parent contacts them. This isn't a sign anything went wrong on your end, but it helps leadership be prepared and shows you're being proactive about a shared concern.

4 Revised Response

Thank you for reaching out, and I understand why a grade that seems different from your son's usual performance is concerning.

The rubric and project directions were shared with the class multiple times, both verbally and in writing, and most students were able to complete the project using those materials. I'm glad to sit down with your son, walk through the rubric point by point, and show him exactly where points were earned or lost so it's clear how the grade was determined.

I want to be transparent that I'm not able to change a grade simply based on a request, but I am very willing to review the specific project with you or your son if you believe something was scored in error. If you'd like, we can set up a short call or meeting this week to go through it together.

I also recognize you mentioned other families have raised concerns about this assignment. I take that seriously and will be reflecting on how the project and rubric were presented for the future.